

Constitution inheritance — operator & agent guide

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This guide explains how Herald inherits from the Helix Universal Constitution, why Herald does **not** keep its own copy, how the runtime discovery contract works, and how the inheritance gate enforces both.

If you only need the rule, read [§Summary](#) and stop. If you're operating Herald, building tooling around it, or debugging a FAIL 11 from the gate, read on.

Summary

- Herald **does not** carry a constitution/ submodule.
- Herald is consumed as a submodule of a parent project that **already provides** <parent>/constitution/.
- For standalone Herald work, clone the constitution **alongside** Herald (`(dirname "$PWD")/constitution`), never inside.
- The inheritance contract is enforced by `tests/test_constitution_inheritance.sh` (gate) and `tests/test_constitution_inheritance_meta.sh` (paired §1.1 mutation proof).
- Discovery uses parent-walk: walk up directories until you find <ancestor>/constitution/Constitution.md.

Why no embedded submodule?

Herald is a building block. It will be used as a submodule by several parent projects. Each parent already includes the Helix Constitution at <parent>/constitution/. If Herald also carried its own constitution/:

1. **Two pins, one source of truth.** The parent and Herald could pin to different constitution SHAs, silently disagreeing on which clauses apply. Constitution §3 requires submodule commits propagate first — duplicate copies make the propagation order undefined.
2. **Doubled storage** for a 250 KB content set that should be shared.
3. **Confusion about authority.** Two constitution/CLAUDE.md files (one at <parent>/constitution/, one at <parent>/Herald/constitution/) is exactly the kind of "which file wins?" ambiguity the anti-bluff covenant exists to prevent.

Herald therefore inherits from the parent's constitution and provides only a discovery mechanism to locate it.

Discovery contract

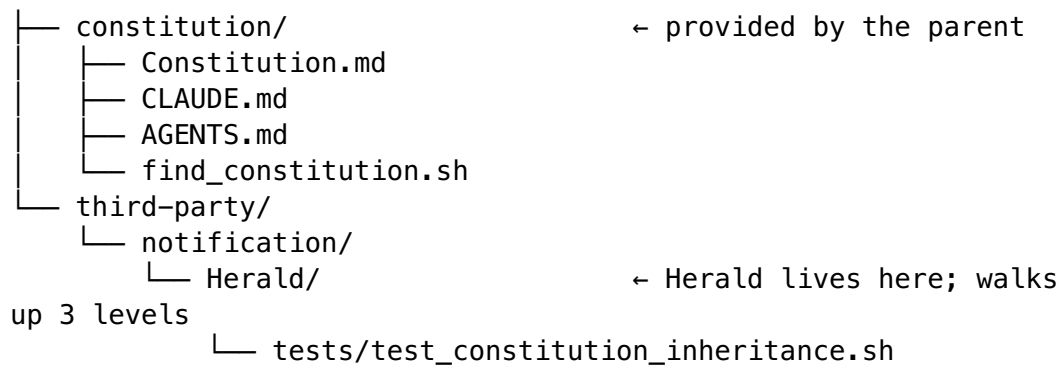
Discovery uses the same algorithm as the canonical `find_constitution.sh` (Phase 1):

1. Start at Herald's repo root.
2. Walk up parent directories.
3. At each step, check whether <dir>/constitution/Constitution.md exists.
4. First match wins; print its absolute path and exit 0.
5. If no ancestor matches, exit non-zero with an error.

This works at any nesting depth:

```
SomeBigProject/  
constitution/
```

← parent project, ships



From Herald's gate, the parent-walk visits Herald/ → notification/ → third-party/ → SomeBigProject/ and matches at the last step.

Standalone development

If you cloned just Herald (no parent project), put a clone of the constitution **alongside** Herald — exactly mirroring the Projects/ layout used during Herald's bootstrap:

```
git clone git@github.com:HelixDevelopment/HelixConstitution.git \
  $(dirname "$PWD")/constitution
```

This gives you Projects/Herald/ (your work) and Projects/constitution/ (the sibling). Parent-walk from Herald visits Herald/ → Projects/ and matches.

Do not clone the constitution inside Herald. The gate's invariant I6 will FAIL if <repo-root>/constitution/ or .gitmodules reappears.

The inheritance gate

tests/test_constitution_inheritance.sh is read-only and idempotent. It asserts:

Invariant	What it checks
I1	A constitution/Constitution.md is reachable via parent-walk from Herald's repo root. Prints the discovered path.
I2	The discovered Constitution.md contains the exact line <code>### §11.4 End-user quality guarantee – forensic anchor (User mandate, 2026-04-28)</code> . This is the line the §1.1 mutation removes; the gate's I2 and the mutation's removal are paired by design.
I3	The discovered CLAUDE.md contains <code>MANDATORY ANTI-BLUFF COVENANT</code> .
I4	The discovered AGENTS.md contains <code>Anti-bluff covenant</code> .
I5a	Herald's CLAUDE.md declares <code>INHERITED FROM Helix Constitution</code> and references <code>find_constitution.sh</code> .
I5b	Herald's AGENTS.md references <code>find_constitution.sh</code> .
I5c	

Invariant	What it checks
	docs/guides/HERALD_CONSTITUTION.md extends the Helix Universal Constitution.
I5d	README.md documents the Helix Constitution inheritance contract.
I6	No constitution/ directory or .gitmodules file exists at Herald's root (§104).

Run:

```
bash tests/test_constitution_inheritance.sh
```

Expected output on a healthy tree:

```
PASS I1 constitution discovered at /Users/<you>/Projects/
constitution
PASS I2 Constitution.md contains §11.4 forensic anchor
PASS I3 constitution/CLAUDE.md contains anti-bluff covenant
anchor
PASS I4 constitution/AGENTS.md contains anti-bluff covenant
anchor
PASS I5a CLAUDE.md declares Helix Constitution inheritance
(parent-discovery)
PASS I5b AGENTS.md references the parent-provided constitution +
find_constitution.sh
PASS I5c HERALD_CONSTITUTION.md extends the Helix Universal
Constitution
PASS I5d README.md documents the constitution-inheritance
contract
PASS I6 No constitution submodule embedded in Herald
-----
Result: 9 PASS / 0 FAIL
```

Non-zero exit means at least one invariant FAILED; fix the offending invariant at root cause per Universal §11.4.4 (test-interrupt-on-discovery).

Common failure: **FAIL I1 constitution NOT found ...**

Means there's no <ancestor>/constitution/Constitution.md reachable above Herald. Either:

- **You're working standalone** — clone the constitution as a sibling (see [Standalone development](#)).
- **You're inside a parent project that lacks the constitution submodule** — fix the parent. Herald is not the right place to fix this.

Common failure: **FAIL I6 No constitution submodule embedded in Herald**

Means somebody re-added constitution/ inside Herald (a §104 violation). Remove it cleanly:

```
git submodule deinit -f constitution
git rm -f constitution
rm -rf .git/modules/constitution
# If .gitmodules becomes empty, delete it too:
[ ! -s .gitmodules ] && git rm -f .gitmodules
```

The paired mutation meta-test (§1.1)

tests/test_constitution_inheritance_meta.sh is the proof that the gate is not itself a bluff. Per Universal §1.1, every gate must have a paired mutation demonstrating it catches the regression it claims to catch.

The meta-test:

1. Discovers the constitution (same algorithm as the gate).
2. Delegates to <discovered>/meta_test_inheritance.sh, passing Herald's gate as the command-under-test.
3. The constitution's meta-runner snapshots Constitution.md, strips the §11.4 anchor, runs Herald's gate, asserts the gate exits non-zero, then restores the file.
4. If the gate exited zero with the anchor removed, the meta-test fails with META-TEST FAIL: gate returned 0 even though the §11.4 anchor was removed.

Run:

```
bash tests/test_constitution_inheritance_meta.sh
```

Expected output on a healthy tree:

```
Mutation applied: §11.4 anchor removed from Constitution.md
Running consuming-project gate: bash '/.../tests/
test_constitution_inheritance.sh' > /dev/null 2>&1
✓ META-TEST PASS: gate correctly FAILED (rc=1) on mutated
Constitution
```

The restore happens via trap inside the constitution-side runner; if you ever see a .bak file alongside Constitution.md after a meta-test run, the restore was interrupted — restore manually from the .bak.

When to run the gates

- **Before any commit that touches root docs** (CLAUDE.md, AGENTS.md, README.md), docs/guides/, or tests/test_constitution_inheritance*.
- **After cloning** Herald standalone, immediately after cloning the constitution sibling.
- **In CI** as a precondition to any other test (catches drift early).
- **When integrating Herald into a new parent project** to confirm discovery works at the new nesting depth.

Promoting Herald rules into the constitution

If Herald grows a rule that genuinely deserves universal status (applies to ≥ 3 unrelated projects, references no Herald-specific tech, encodes a policy not a configuration value), promote it via the HelixConstitution repo, not by editing the parent's constitution/ from Herald. Universal §11.4 + §11.4.10 require this audit; the default is to keep rules in docs/guides/HERALD_CONSTITUTION.md until the audit clears.

Glossary

- **Parent project** — the larger project that includes Herald as a submodule and provides <parent>/constitution/.
- **Discovered constitution** — the result of parent-walk; the absolute path printed by bash <ancestor>/constitution/find_constitution.sh or by I1 of Herald's gate.
- **Forensic anchor** — the exact line ### §11.4 End-user quality guarantee – forensic anchor (User mandate, 2026-04-28). The gate checks for it; the meta-test removes it.
- **Bluff gate** — a gate that returns PASS without actually checking the thing it claims to check. Universal §1.1 forbids them; paired mutations are the mechanism that catches them.